

A DATA-DRIVEN MARKET STUDY

The Indie Startup Economy

Segmenting the solo-founder & AI micro-SaaS market

1,000 startups • verified live revenue via Stripe & RevenueCat • frozen 30 Jul 2026

Source: TrustMRR dataset, Session 3 (1,000-row snapshot)

What are we actually looking at?

In plain terms: this is the world of solo founders and tiny teams who build small software products — apps, AI tools, browser extensions — and sell them online. No investors, no big offices. Just a product, a payment link, and real customers.

Why trust the numbers?

Every business here connects its real payment account (Stripe, RevenueCat, and similar) to TrustMRR, which reads the actual revenue directly — not a number the founder typed in. Think of it like a verified bank statement instead of a resume.



1 person or a tiny team

Most “companies” here are one founder, sometimes two.



Sold online, worldwide

A product built in Paris can have paying users in Tokyo by lunchtime.



Priced in subscriptions

Monthly Recurring Revenue (MRR) is the market’s scoreboard.

How big is this market, really?

1,000

startups tracked in this snapshot

\$13.5M

combined Monthly Recurring
Revenue (MRR)

\$133.8M

revenue generated in the last 12
months

\$334M

combined all-time revenue across
all startups

What this tells a normal person

This is a real, sizeable economy — over **a third of a billion dollars** earned all-time by ordinary builders, not venture-backed unicorns. But as we'll see, that money is **not spread evenly** — a small number of standout products earn the majority of it.

Four ways we sliced the market

01

By niche / category

AI, SaaS, Education, Marketing, E-commerce and 20+ more — what the product actually does.

02

By geography

Which country the founder or company is based in.

03

By business model

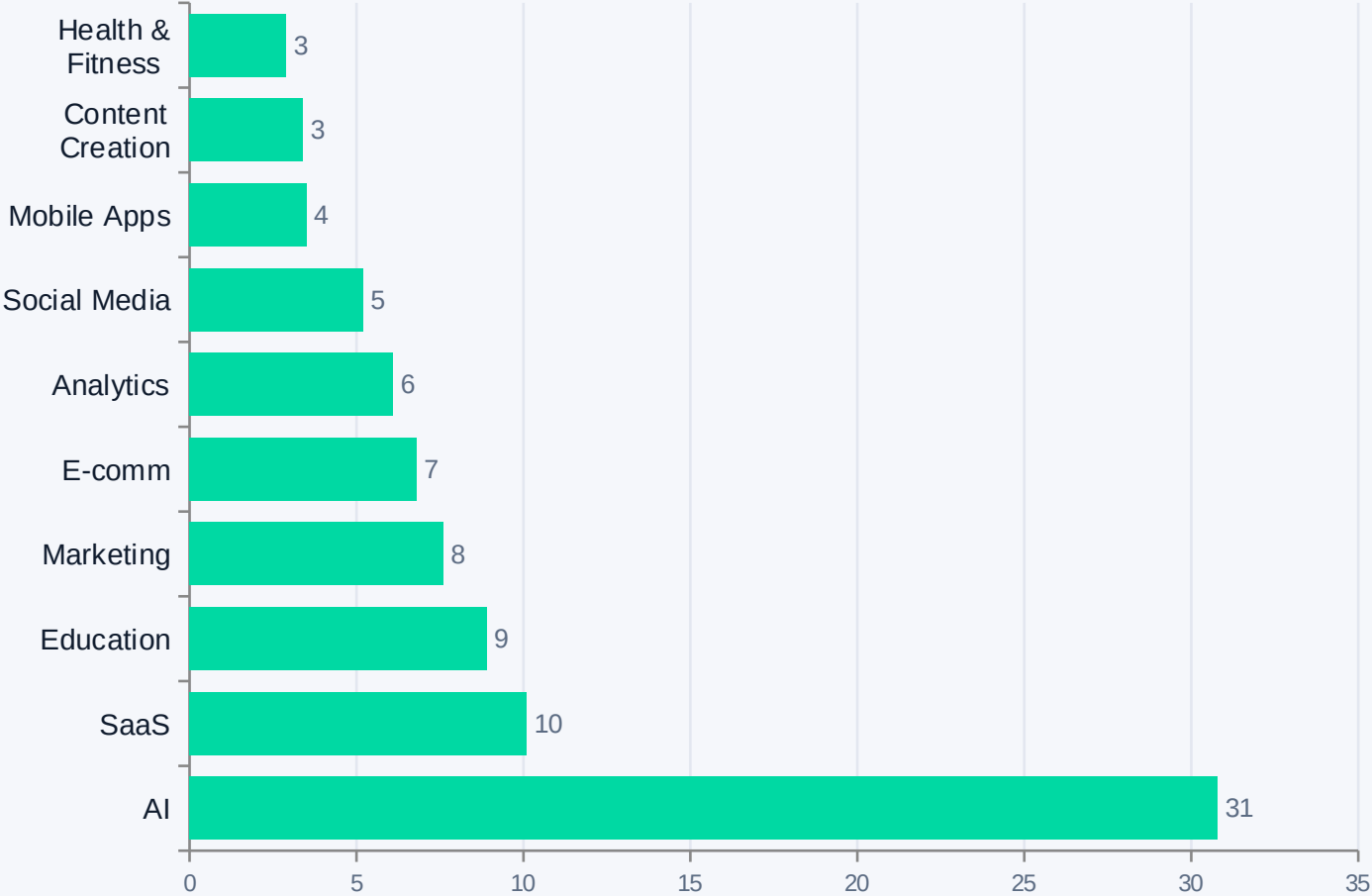
Subscription pricing, one-time purchase, freemium — and which payment platform powers it.

04

By audience

Selling to consumers (B2C), businesses (B2B), or both.

AI dominates — but the market has many niches



Reading this chart

AI tools alone generate **31%** of all category revenue — nearly 3× the next niche, SaaS.

197 startups (1 in 5 in this dataset) are building on AI, from writing assistants to automation tools.

The other 70% is spread across education, marketing, e-commerce and dozens of smaller niches.

Niche #1: AI tools

197

startups building AI products

\$1.81M

combined monthly revenue

+16.7%

average 30-day MRR growth

Why AI is the market leader right now

- **Cheaper to build:** AI coding assistants let one person ship a working product in days, not months.
- **Clear, sellable value:** “this saves you hours” is an easy pitch for automation and writing tools.
- **Everyone needs it:** from students to sales teams, AI tools sell across almost every audience type.

The other proven niches

NICHE	COUNT	MONTHLY REV.	WHAT IT MEANS
SaaS	66	\$588.7K	General business software — CRMs, dashboards, internal tools.
Education	30	\$523.7K	Online courses, tutoring and learning tools — fewer players, high revenue each.
Marketing	42	\$444.5K	SEO, ads, and growth tools for other small businesses.
E-commerce	19	\$395.7K	Storefronts, product tools, and online-selling add-ons.
Analytics	19	\$357.8K	Simple dashboards and privacy-friendly tracking tools.

MARKET LEADERS

Who's leading the market today

#	STARTUP	NICHE	COUNTRY	MONTHLY REV.	SUBSCRIBERS
1	Stan	Creator tools (link-in-bio)	US	\$3.57M	101,590
2	GojiberryAI	AI	US	\$494.7K	4,642
3	Rezi	AI (resume writing)	US	\$259.7K	10,749
4	Kibu	Education	US	\$234.3K	375
5	Cometly	Analytics	US	\$207.6K	307
6	1Lookup	SaaS	US	\$207.1K	655
7	Brand On Demand	E-commerce	US	\$187.5K	3,631
8	Postiz	Social media tools	Hong Kong	\$177.1K	5,237

MARKET LEADER SPOTLIGHT

Meet the runaway leader: Stan

Stan is a “link-in-bio” storefront: creators use it to sell courses, coaching and digital products directly to their social media following — no separate website needed.

Its \$3.57M in monthly revenue is bigger than the **combined MRR of the next seven leading startups** in this dataset — a single product effectively anchors the whole creator-tools niche.

\$3.57M

monthly recurring revenue

101,590

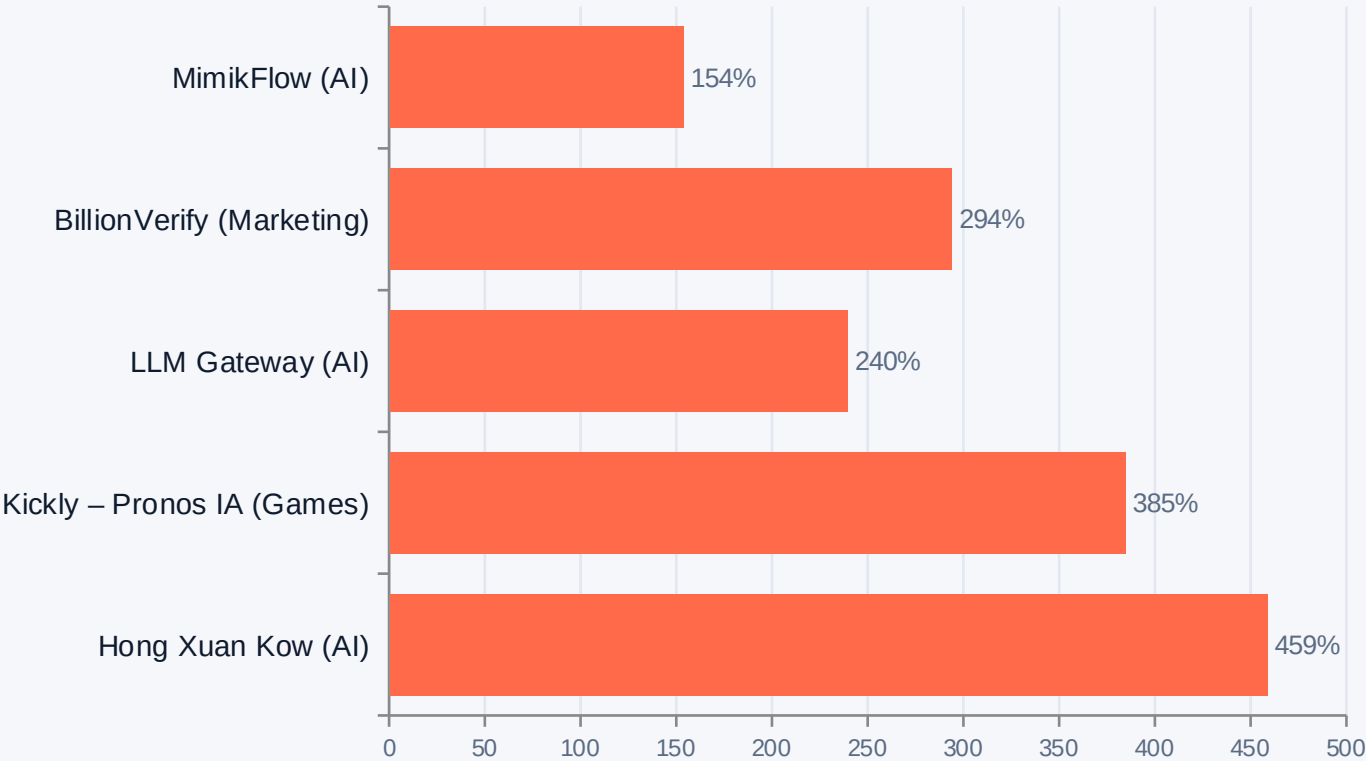
active paying subscribers

\$25.0M

revenue in the past 12 months

Who could be the next big player?

Looking past today’s size, these startups are growing their revenue the fastest month-over-month — the early signals of tomorrow’s leaders.

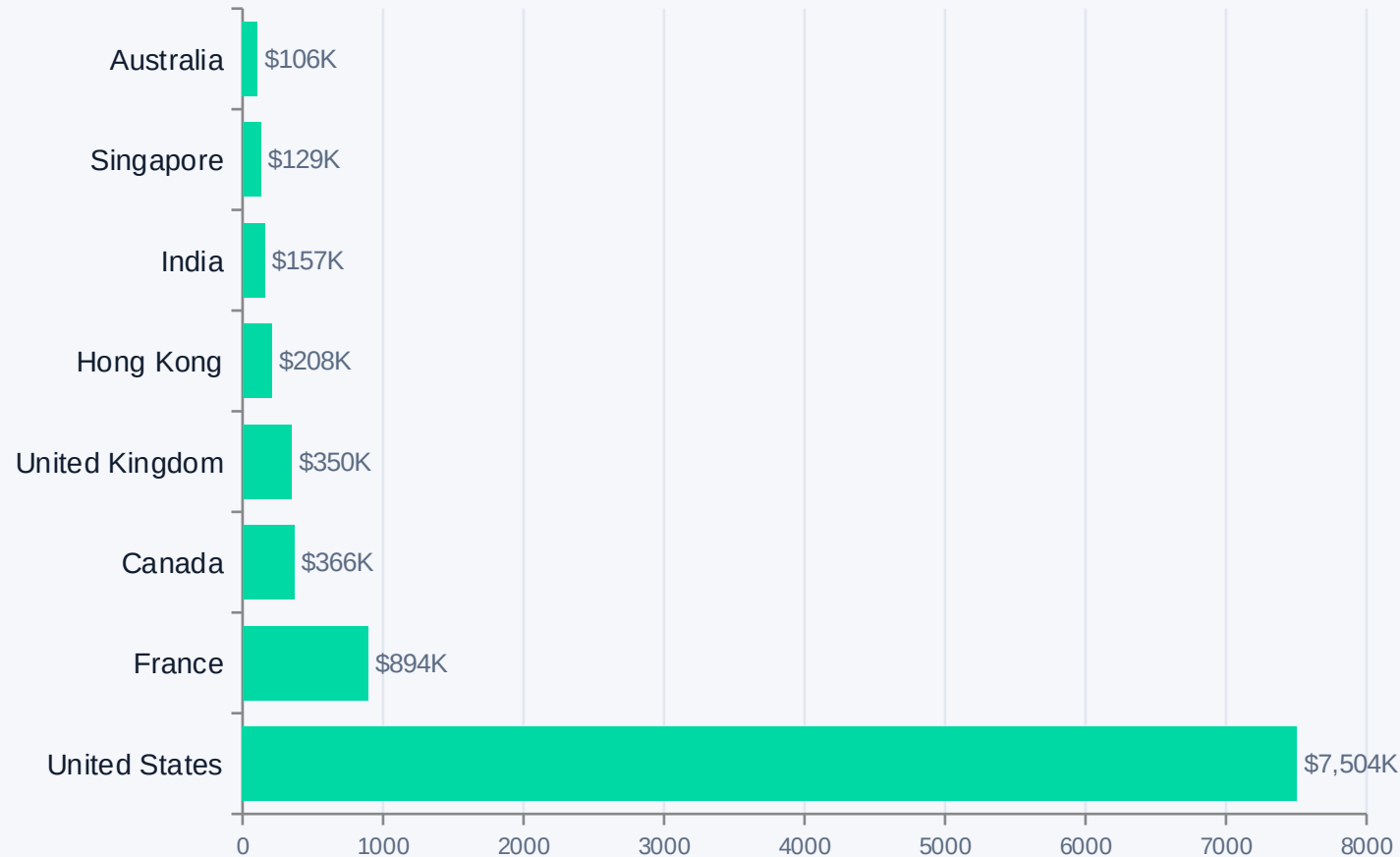


What “growth” means here

These are small businesses today (most under \$50K/month) — **but growing 2–5× faster** than the market average.

Fast growth from a small base is normal and can slow down — it’s a signal to watch, not a guarantee.

The market is global — but US-centered



Three things stand out

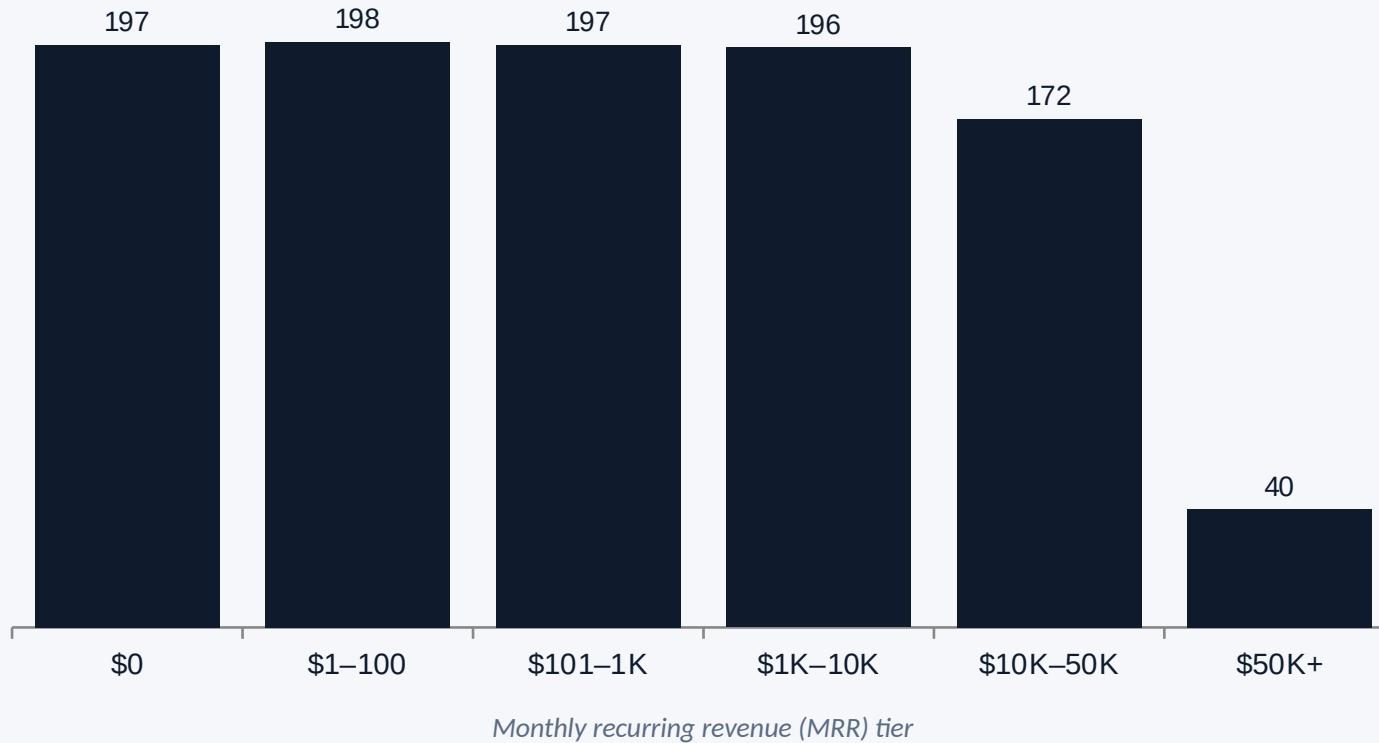
United States leads decisively — **258 startups** and \$7.5M of monthly revenue, over half the visible market.

France is a strong #2 with 79 startups — a notably active indie-founder scene.

India has volume, not yet value: 59 startups but modest revenue so far — room to grow.

Note: 241 startups have no listed country and are excluded from this view.

A classic winner-take-most market



The math behind it

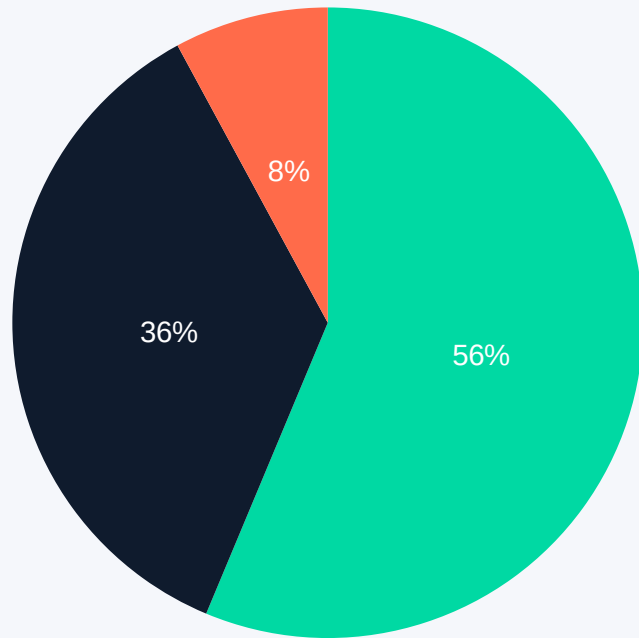
Nearly 4 in 10 startups (395 of 1,000) earn \$100/month or less — essentially pre-revenue.

Just 40 startups (4%) have crossed \$50K/month — and they account for the bulk of all revenue.

Median MRR: \$282 — the “typical” startup here is still a side-project-sized business.

How these businesses charge money

Who they sell to



■ Consumers (B2C) ■ Businesses (B2B) ■ Both

What powers their payments



Stripe

636 startups — the default for web-based SaaS & subscriptions



RevenueCat

189 startups — the standard for mobile app subscriptions



Dodo, Polar, Lemon Squeezy + others

175 startups — newer, indie-friendly billing tools

Why this market exists right now

AI lowered the cost of building software

Tools that write and debug code mean one person can now do the work that used to take a small dev team.

The creator economy needs infrastructure

As more people build an audience online, they need simple tools to turn followers into paying customers — exactly what leaders like Stan provide.

Payments got easier to plug in

Services like Stripe and RevenueCat mean a solo founder can start charging money on day one, no finance team required.

Remote, global-by-default

A founder in France or India can sell to customers in the US the moment they launch — no local office needed.

This market runs on creators, not companies

Behind almost every listing is one founder — often building in public, sharing progress and revenue screenshots on social media. Their following isn't vanity: it's their marketing department.

Startups with the largest social following

DataFast	Analytics	365,925 followers	\$25.1K/mo
TrustMRR	Marketplace	365,925 followers	\$22.3K/mo
POST BRIDGE	Social tools	153,159 followers	\$41.8K/mo
SEOBOT	AI	116,698 followers	\$49.7K/mo

The takeaway

A big audience helps a launch — but it doesn't guarantee revenue. Several of the largest followings on this list earn less than smaller, more focused products. Building the right thing still matters more than reach alone.

56%

of startups sell directly to everyday consumers (B2C)

Under-served niches = open opportunity

Not every niche is crowded. A handful of categories have almost no listed players yet — which can mean untapped opportunity, or simply an early, unproven space. Worth investigating either way.

1 startup

Crypto & Web3

1 startup

Legal

1 startup

News & Magazines

4 startups

No-Code tools

5 startups

Community platforms

5 startups

Customer Support

Could you build one of these yourself?

1

Pick a real, narrow problem

Not “an AI app” — “an AI tool that writes follow-up emails for real-estate agents.” Specific beats broad.

2

Build fast with today’s tools

AI coding assistants + no-code platforms let a beginner ship a working version in days.

3

Charge from day one

Even \$9/month via Stripe. Real paying customers, not sign-ups, are the only proof that matters.

4

Grow with your own voice

Share your build-in-public journey where your future customers already are — X, TikTok, or niche communities.

5

Track real numbers, not vanity ones

Watch MRR and active subscribers, the same way this whole market is measured — not likes or downloads.

Key takeaways



AI is the clear leading niche

31% of category revenue, 197 startups — nearly 3× the next-biggest segment.



One product can define a niche

Stan's \$3.57M MRR outweighs the next seven leaders combined — leadership is concentrated.



It's a long-tail market

4 in 10 startups earn under \$100/month; only 4% break \$50K — most are still early-stage.



The US leads, but the market is global

France, India, and the UK all have active, growing founder communities.



Consumers, not just businesses, are the biggest buyers

56% of startups sell B2C — everyday people are this market's core customer.



The barrier to entry has never been lower

AI build tools + simple payments mean anyone with a real idea can start today.

Read the data with these caveats

- This is a snapshot frozen on 30 Jul 2026, not a live feed — numbers shift daily in reality.
- About 1 in 4 startups had no listed category or country — those gaps are noted, not guessed at.
- “Stealth Company” and “Unnamed Company” entries are founders who chose to stay anonymous — real businesses, hidden names.
- This dataset reflects who chose to connect and verify — it’s a large, representative sample of the indie market, not every company in the world.

Thank you

Source: TrustMRR 1,000-row dataset, Session 3, frozen 30 Jul 2026.